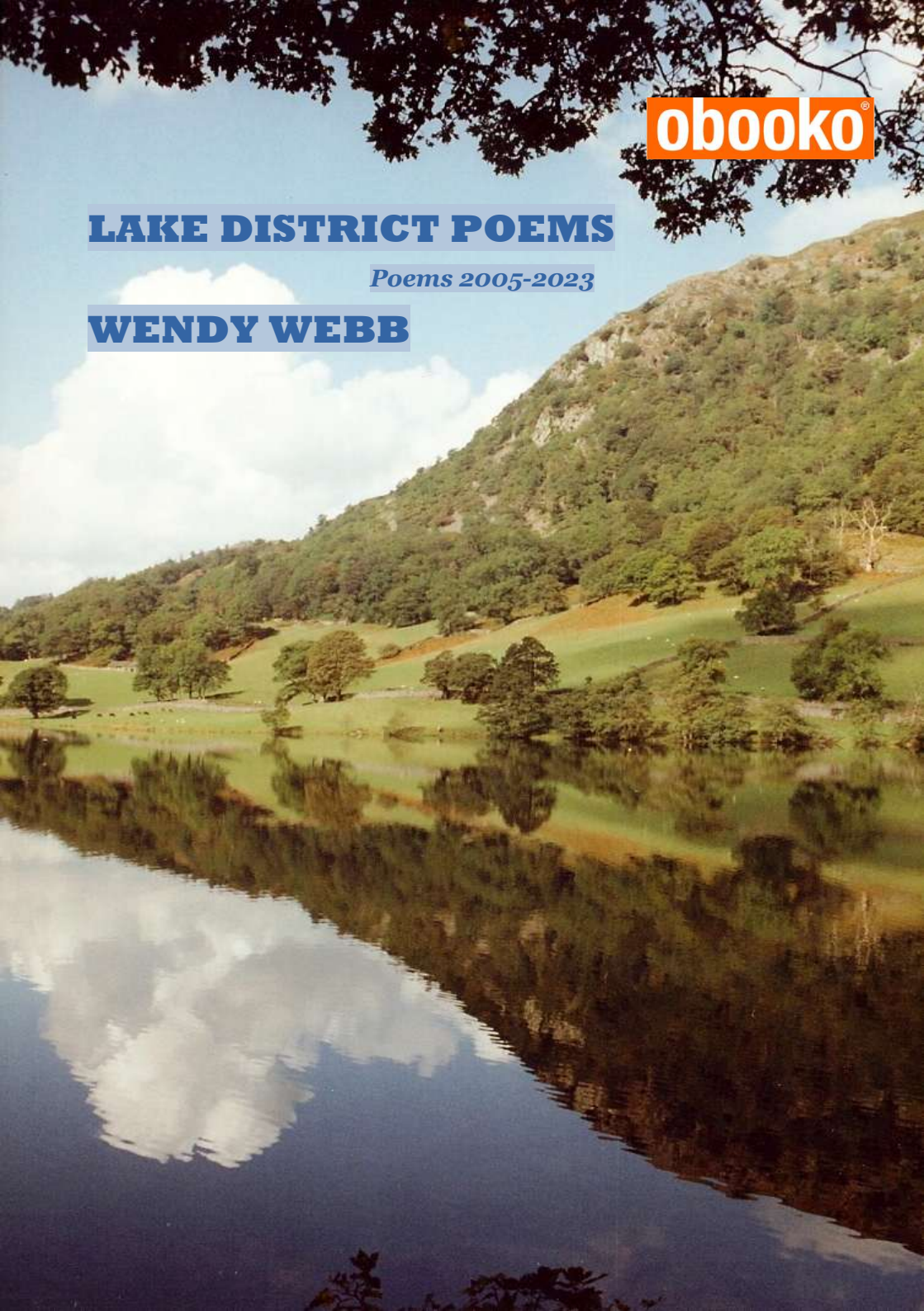

obooko
LAKE DISTRICT POEMS
Poems 2005-2023
WENDY WEBB

Free Evaluation Edition from obooko.com

© Copyright 2025 Wendy Ann Webb

Published by the author. Distributed worldwide by obooko

This edition is available free of charge exclusively to obooko members for evaluation purposes only. It may be amended and updated at any time by the author so please visit www.obooko.com to ensure you have the latest edition.

This book must not be copied or printed unless the author has given written permission for personal printing. It must not be sold in digital or printed form nor offered free or for sale on any website other than www.obooko.com.

For more free ebooks and to list your fiction or non-fiction book for free publication, please visit www.obooko.com

CONTENTS

Table of Contents

WILD RAMBLINGS BY THE LAKES....5
BOOMING LANDSCAPES FOR THE POET....7
WILLIAM'S BENEDICTION....8
IT IS A BEAUTIFUL EVENING....9
IN PRAISE OF LADY LUCY....10
HOMELY BEACONS AT NIGHT....11
MUSIC OF THE UNIVERSE....12
BEYOND DUDDON (HARDKNOTT AND WRYNOSE PASS)....12
TO THE CUCKOO CLOCK (23RD APRIL 1850)....13
WHEN BEAUTIFUL IS THE ONLY WORD....14
LEAVING DUDDON....15
FRAMING DUDDON....16
GRAVE READING....17
LAKELAND DRENCHING SOUTH....18
DANDELION AND 19
POET TO POET: AN EXHORTATION....20
UNREFLECTING KEATS....21
'SO WE'LL KISS NO MORE AND TELL, DEAR'....21
DORA'S FIELD....22
STEPPING STONES....23
GRASMERE....24
BETJEMAN IN GRASMERE....25
LOUGHRIGG TERRACE....26
I SHOULD HAVE LOOKED AFTER ME FEET....27
CONISTON....28
STOCK GHYLL....29
SOPHIE AT RYDAL WATER....30
FELIXSTOWE BARD AT GRASMERE....31
TYNESIDE BARD UP KIRKSTONE PASS....32
AIRA BECK....33
BOWDERSTONE BEYOND DERWENTWATER....34
AMBLESIDE....35
JOHN CLARE AT WATERHEAD....36
KEATS IN THE PARK....37
HIGH SWEDEN BRIDGE....38
THE STRUGGLE....39

LOW SWEDEN BRIDGE....40
AIRA FORCE....41
LA MÉRIDIENNE OU LA SIESTE....42
FAST FOOD....43
CHICKEN....43
ROAD KILL....44
HIGHWAY....44
THE LAKES....45
IN FLIGHT....45
THE BRIGHTEST STARS....46
RISING HILLS....47
IAMBIC FEET....47
VIEWS INTO WINDERMERE....48
TUCKED IN....49
EYEBALL TO EYEBALL....50
LOUGHRIGG TERRACE....51
CANVAS....52
MOODS AT RYDAL MOUNT....52
JENKYN'S CRAG....53
TROUTBECK....54
DERWENTWATER....54
HOT TUB....55
ON THE DOORSTEP....56
COUPLE AT WATERHEAD....56
A LUCKY HORSESHOE....57
GRASMERE....59
LUNCH IN WINDERMERE....60
ROUTE TO CONISTON....61
STORMS AND SUNSHINE....61
THIRLMERE....62
ON TOP OF THE FAIRFIELD HORSESHOE....63
MORE ABOUT THE HORSESHOE....63
HERDWICKS AND CLOUDS....64
SIGHTS OF KESWICK....65
WINDERMERE IN RAIN....65
YOUTH....66
STOCK GHYLL....67
AT THE PETROL STATION....68
LEAVING....69
THIS AND THAT....70
DISINTEGRATION SONNET....71

BEYOND STOCK GHYLL.....72
THE ELLERAY, WINDERMERE.....73
WATERHEAD TO WINDERMERE GOODBYE.....74
LAKES BY BUS.....75
PARADISE LOST IN DECEMBER.....77
THE 508.....78
ROOM WITH THIS VIEW.....78
THE 508 RETURNS TO WINDERMERE.....79
THE 555.....80
THE BOAT TRIP.....81
I WANDERED BOWDERSTONE TO GRASMERE VIA KENDAL AND WATERHEAD.....82
NOTES.....85

WILD RAMBLINGS BY THE LAKES

They wandered across,
two pale heifers on a footbridge
above a motorway of herding lorries, flocking cars,
ambling north up the M6 to Kendal;
bleating beside Windermere and beyond - Grasmere.

Dorothy could have penned a tail or two about cows.
Cattle herd, they don't 'wander lonely as…
a cloud.'

William, reclining on his chaise longue,
or wandering, lonely as a postman,
could have dictated to Dorothy.
Cumberland clouds were not lonely for long:

soon they tumbled
- scattered across hills, then captured -
flocks in a sheep dip.
Lonely wool snagged on brambles.

Vapours isolated in parchment sky;
feather-breeze, ink spilt and blotched.
Dark-coated as lambs, ageing grey,
wild as fells and bracken snaring berries,
heafing home in sweet, rambling delicacy.
Rain pounding Herdwick hooves,
skies cloven by shades of grey,
obscuring, blurring, bleating wind and storm.

Nowadays, lonely postmen on their bikes,
carpet bags stuffed fat like grey fleece
newly-shorn and wasted,
have no time to stop and stare,
scribble silk-stockinged verse.
Flocks of junk mail arrive late,
herding from the M6 and two stray wandering cows.

Now for golden sunshine after rain:
hosts of tourists clouding lakes,
confined to Wordsworth's natal star.
Oh for Ullswater, transe-like, brooding
and that first brash daffodil of spring.

BOOMING LANDSCAPES FOR THE POET

Bold Wordsworth boomed and scared poor native verve
and shot his gait with muse, a human bow,
to string the quivered air before his quill
and shatter phantom ink on night's dark page.
He, passionless, bled cost to candlelight,
boomed life into his art to heighten form,
threw shadow-years of phrases, walling thought.

Bold woodland terrace, built to promenade,
shoots arrows straight as dreams in midday skies,
disquieting lanes and vistas' calm lake moods,
to soothing highs and lows of birds in flight.
Glide softly over deluge, flooding sense,
old staring pools, viewed fresh in cold bare verse.
A poet thrives in stepping's booming flow.

I shall be bold when writing mentored verse
and boom fermenting sounds into damp air,
see visions fount and fizzing prose evolve
to torrents framing echoes, rounding forms,
so downpours shape smooth stones of artless themes.
Teased mind-games raise scared boomings, seasons past -
forged ghostly nature looms, a path in flood.

WILLIAM'S BENEDICTION

She wandered round her garden lawn
and circled with a piece of string.
Infinity spun from that ball,
to weave maze daffodils in spring.

Enchanted by his fine design –
a scribbling child's brash windowsill –
buff-polishing translucent dreams,
obscure, his friend the gnome, sat still.

And as she pointed to the crowd,
one hundred balls of packaged bliss,
he traced God's finger, Adam's breath,
dropped, one by one, Eve's eggs like this:-

Gnome-littered scripts, so statuesque,
night's mystic moves to waning moon –
his fishing line, stretched taut and flat
to reel his catch, a rustic rune.

Poor mum was left to till bare earth,
laid bulbs to rest in time for tea;
she navigated shrivelled sacks,
like proud flotillas lost at sea.

Frail autumn's skin of arcing leaves,
and acorns dull as buried sod,
raised brine's fleshed bones before cruel snow
to point like fingers back to God.

And as mum wandered round her lawn,
she marked white lines with playpen string;
confounded how a mythic gnome
could guard her charges, green till spring.

And soon a child will dance, amazed –
no pots nor flowers on windowsills –
sun's gleaming lights on polished panes:
Will's golden host, mass daffodils.

IT IS A BEAUTIFUL EVENING
['It is a Beauteous Evening' William Wordsworth, for his French daughter Caroline, aged 9]

Tides set to lunar cycles, seeming free
as plainsong in a chapel, when each nun
releases compline to the setting sun,
enchanting night in deep tranquillity.
Her silence lasts till matins' lauding sea
- for she has slept, but kept her soul awake -
so rising tides flow by the bell, to make
devotion's morning - everlastingly.
Now youngsters at the seaside – running here
and there, all nonsense, carelessness of thought –
dip flesh and soul, terse in the sea, divine
with nature's cycles, sexed in solar year.
Each man and woman's child builds vespers' shrine
to compline's seashore… yet they know it not.

IN PRAISE OF LADY LUCY
[iso 'Strange Fits of Passion'/'She Dwelt Among the Untrodden Ways'/William Wordsworth]

Strange fits of passion I will tell
to all who read this ode,
sweet Lucy's star will never sell;
the black sky's her abode.

None cares a jot for my sweet girl,
eyes violet, moss and dull.
None praise her petals, they unfurl
like rocks, so fat and full.

So only death is kind to her;
no grave is less unknown.
I love her, though none others stir,
applause grows more full-blown.

I love her like a rose in June,
when dark disguises thorns.
My eyes moon nature's distant tune,
dilemma's dressed in horns.

Dream Lady Lucy rides me high
to passions fitting, strange.
The moon and Equus raise a sigh;
my planets rearrange.

Such wayward fancies slip and slide
into my loving head,
if mounted on my steed I glide
within my Lucy's bed.

HOMELY BEACONS AT NIGHT

Low morbid cloud lays grey wrapped into sky
and sinks like chimney smoke in eerie gloom.
A black sheet dips towards the darkened soil,
on pricks of frail illumined feint pin-shine.
White houses hint at distance, standing clear
and pale grass drifts as frost's November fields.
Land darkens, fading, lost in gentler air,
while dusk-prods grasp a spacescape, alien-slow.

Horizons stab dense lamps of flicking strength
and trees stand dark with symmetry and form.
Deep blankets sink to tuck pale land in dusk,
to snuggle safely, hiding phantom shades.
Now dark is powerless in restful sleep.

Then, mirrored from drab earth towards the sky,
surge rockets wraithe dull looking glass in flame
and bonfires, ancient beacons of the light,
wrap night to night securely beyond view.

I saw, in flagrante delicto, the mount
where Wordsworth owned his ancient garden's past -
knew musing words, as beacons, bright enough
to scare marauders wrapped in Lakeland cloud.

Then hours of darkness, simply cold and long,
prowled no more space of alien, evil ships;
henceforth hereafter's good proved all was well,
for nightmares had no place in heaven or earth:
and if there was no God, then death was peace,
and, if there was, sane hope could never die -
then dawn was near, for morning always came.

MUSIC OF THE UNIVERSE
[iso 'Wisdom and Spirit of the Universe' by William Wordsworth]

'A grandeur in the beatings of the art'
to rhythm life in sweet futility,
to pound the pin-prick stars' performing part,
wrap heavenly bodies, sweet with infancy
and fall upon the surging milky way:
nurse flesh to fancy's bones for fantasy.

Let's bring to earth a comet, lest it stray
beyond each heartbeat's ordinary note,
to orchestrate all instruments to play
and grandly raise a mountain range afloat.
Place destiny upon a wooden seat,
reflections in the lake around our boat.
So art will paint the landscape where we meet
and heartbeats make the symphony complete.

BEYOND DUDDON (Hardknott and Wrynose Pass)
[iso 'The River Duddon' by William Wordsworth]

My partner, through the mountain range we climb
round sharp bends, one-in-three, towards the sky,
then in first gear we brake to steer, not fly;
I'm glad that we're not caught in mists of time.
The river's hush and lakes' abandoned flow,
transitioning throughout earth's history,
dream timelessly, lull temporality
to silence, gravely gone, so far below.
Steep perils lie beneath, we look at sheep
and words have hooves to leap our worth up higher
to waterfalls in flood to drench desire
in plainer prose that souls will want to keep.
Then gulls will glide inland on storm-swept power,
their transient Function fade to Forms complete.

TO THE CUCKOO CLOCK (23rd April 1850)

['To the Cuckoo' by William Wordsworth. Wordsworth died on St George's Day (also Shakespeare's Day); the clock given to Wordsworth by Miss Fenwick was striking twelve, later on display at Dove Cottage, not Rydal Mount]

O Cuckoo Clock, O Cuckoo Clock,
winged sleep to foreign doors.
You mocked lake hours to tick-tock
for bards of Grasmere's shores.

I saw you there upon the stairs
and watched you sound just twice:
soon vanished, like a graveside prayer,
where words would not suffice.

You did not rise or, like a dove,
coo quietly in the gloom,
or cottage gentle Mary's love,
who stoked to light this room.

For ten years, plaintive cuckoo calls
performed gold clockwork duty:
late Rydal Mount's timed evening falls
to darling failing beauty.

Moot Fenwick clock's mute noon, dust-shelved,
feigned night, fainted away.
Brash cuckoo sounded glorious twelve,
sprung bardic England's Day.

WHEN BEAUTIFUL IS THE ONLY WORD

Pretty prose at every twist.
I look for less Wordsworthian themes to write
about this mountain valley's grey-flushed sight.
My chamber pen could dip bog depths of stone,
erupting tissue, magma's glorious throne.

But I can find no other wordless site
that rises to heaven's crest as if by right,
in sun or storm, a dinosaur of bones
like bleached lake sheep, or lichened rocks' dull tones.
Pretty prose at every turn.

Pretty prose at every twist.
A valley like Sahara's searing heat;
aged mountains, fading quicksand of green feet.
Pipe's winding stream, iced air in desert nights.
Cars' winding road, dark-blasted moving lights.

Full 1 in 4 lies Wrynose Pass, complete;
as Hardknott Pass stands 1 in 3, replete.
No view's extinct, to wing eternal sights
of ancient stones in palette-toning whites.
Pretty prose at every turn.

LEAVING DUDDON

Walking tapestries eye and thread,
eye and thread with cloven hooves,
cloven to the lichen-threaded rocks
of tapestries stationary as the hills,
a wrynose grimace where the tyre bursts.
Grey flat of useless rubber unbinding to mountain's rim,
hard-knot as a sheep's silhouette stood on a rock:
bleating spectacular sights through careless eyes
blindly following sheepish rocks
and tasteful coarse-root grass.

The engine revs and tires endlessly,
a course's knotted stream,
like woollen darn, not silk,
weaving beauty every cloven step.
Threading to a pattern of repeats,
the blown-out trampling tyre,
grey as sheep, a tarmac-tramping shade
of lichen clutching rock.
Shading designs in 2/3 perspective
to feint horizon.
Beautiful as tapestry pricked close:
full forty years of eye and thread,
eye and thread of wrynose clouds
to cloven heaven
without the gentlest silk
of Wordsworth's cloven tread.
Wrynose Pass of a motorcar;
more heaven here than Duddon.

FRAMING DUDDON

I did not tread the gentle stream, my partner and my guide,
I did not see the sweetest views at every turn and stride.
I did not trek from Wrynose Pass, meander by the beck,
I did not see monotony of grey stones' thrusting wreck.

I clattered with La'al Ratty's roll and bounce and fumbling steam,
from Eskdale to coast's Ravenglas, a shoreline's barren theme.
My mind in ruins from the ride down Hardknott's stunning route,
we took the gentler, sweeter drop of Duddon's well-versed suit.

As mountains rose across the vale, the studio light switch flicked
to scene a portrait damply-new; appraising cameras clicked.
There was nowhere to stand and stare, the layby grazed all land,
loud sun burst on bare rock so clear, like Proms or full brass band.

In Land of Hope and Glory skies, broad panoramas rolled,
no lens could frame a 4 by 6, no ode strip, so untold.
To canvas such formed damp so fair, no artist could repose,
unless black Lakeland clouds appeared, to Herdwick, leap, compose.

In just the time when children bore, I daubed those inkpot hills;
I watched vat-threads of candy floss trace sticks round cotton rills.
This was no place to stand and stare, to wear our fern-drenched crag;
unwillingly to Duddon, tired, but how my soul did lag.

Though Seathwaite swam before my eyes: a brook, a bridge, a path;
an ageing curate's frugal tale could not now earn my wrath.
No heroes trod the gentler stream, I saw no waterfall,
and Wrynose passed in gentle knots, descending heaven's hall.

Ten miles of Duddon, yet one scene: thick acrylic from tubes;
a worklight, canvas, studio bench, soon functioned, rolling lubes.
La'al Ratty back in service, mined by artists brushed in lead,
absorbing blue and black and green, his mind-taint iron-ore red.

I could not live among these rocks, I could not boom and storm,
I could not in a lifetime pen their most delicious form.
The lakes, undressed, would seem too bare; yet dressed, wear Eden's light,
and yet in Norfolk's gentler scenes there is no less to write.

GRAVE READING

I read a poem, William.
You would have appreciated the gentle solitude;
except tourists crowded, reading guides,
not knowing the back end of a sheep from an ode.
They did not know you boomed around the Lakes,
scaring natives with wild diatribes.
They stood, polite as England, or left.
I read in posie far too sweet for the terrain,
as Duddon boomed beautiful.
Then, as the silence cried feebly,
my blood gushing in a waterfall of embarrassment,
an American lady: serious, polite,
asked 'What is that then?
I haven't heard that one before.'
And I smiled, like sunshine through a Lakeland storm,
'That one's mine.'

LAKELAND DRENCHING SOUTH

Last morning dawns to rain, a crying shame
to leave the Lakes, head south and motor home.
The hillside view is lost in blanket mist.
My bedroom curtains, held adrift, fail to raise a flag
to moor the brilliance of the scene,
so I can paint that inward eye
against the rising bliss of solitude.

Nothing but rain collecting around gutters,
telephone wires beading, dripping to the grey courtyard.
Nothing but bedded geraniums to glow
among huddled cottages' Lakeland stone.
Nothing of rolling hills,
nothing left to miss.

Taking a drenching route south,
to flicking windscreen wipers, eyelids dip,
flick and drip and memorise each scene.

Hills steaming, disguising themselves in air,
sky sullen with swollen light,
specks of sheep on the ridge,
horses fencing damply in the field,
trees dulling to shades of rain
as grass brightens like a cornfield.

The 599 routes stoically from Bowness to Grasmere,
no passengers gloriously scening, open-top,
views of cloud on cloud and mist on mist
of Windermere submerged in false gloaming.

Optimistic souvenir stores opening for maudlin trade.
The thriving tourist industry absorbs
a parched and spreading Lake,
unroomed in blanking mist.
It is not far to stop and stare,
to paint upon my inward eye
an autumn cottage kitchen drenched in flame,
the shadows of a homely darkened hearth
and lighter upper room to, pensive, sit
against a rising bliss of solitude.

DANDELION AND …
[iso 'Christabel' by Samuel Taylor Coleridge]

Mum had a lovely grassy plot.
I brewed the spell she loved a lot.
Her flowers multiplied each year,
I picked them, every week, quite clear.

Last trip, my eyesight long grown dim,
picking blooms that belonged to him.
I soon dozed off upon the grass
amongst the red and yellow mass.

His widow screamed and ran from view
as I stirred, groggy, from the brew.
Gravely haunted by mum's fat bum:
my poppy rump and burping tum.

POET TO POET: AN EXHORTATION
[iso 'An Exhortation' by Percy Bysshe Shelley]

Bright chameleon is my mind,
feeding dazzling light and air.
Twenty times a day, you'll find
my changeling soul not there.
Many colours, many shades,
elf-leaved I change to suit;
wrapped in subtlety, I'm mute,
as my stranger body fades –
shooting vine-stem braids.

Visible as unseen mist,
in sobbing, drenching rain.
Sinking bog won't bear your drift,
damping words suck up dull pain.
Sunshine rises to no form,
to bake each pebble me.
Chameleon, so still, you'll see
shades of forest light adorn:
hazes, myriad, warm.

Poets' want of care soon dies
to fame's false bows of love:
slipping, loosing lizard ties,
feintest rainbows lost above.
Gleaning treasures' forest floor,
silenced shades and themes;
lifting others' well-versed dreams.
When but few their fame adore,
colour less to more.

UNREFLECTING KEATS
[iso 'When I have fears that I may cease to be' by John Keats.]

The stars hold truly unreflecting love,
although we draw feint constellation's trace.
They do not weep, or cloud their face to grieve;
but, ordered, shine or orbit where they're placed.
Fair creatures, every book piled high on shelves:
consuming love, caressing each traced leaf,
till grain stores, our own brain cells, raise themselves;
fermenting verse to please a ladylove.
Shall magic, tracing thoughts at midnight, cease
if I, in fear deceased, no longer see?
The world, its fame and love, are all deceived
- for my tide's shore ebbs truth in constancy.
We stand alone, refracting careless stars;
sand-tracing waves, perplexed that life's a farce.

'SO WE'LL KISS NO MORE AND TELL, DEAR'
[iso 'So, we'll go no more a roving' by Lord Byron]

So we'll kiss no more and tell, dear,
though love aches and flames flash strong
and deep hearts thump ever nearer,
pounding hearth where we belong.

For although we breathe together,
sword to sheath's combustion,
our strapped scabbard hearts' whenever
fuels slit-sparking unison.

Though slashed lunar face wanes nearer
eclipsing night's gashed day,
yet we'll no more kiss and tell, dear,
homely love's cosmic replay.

DORA'S FIELD

I wandered lonely Dora's Field,
all winding clouds of daffodils
beneath a Mount, where early yield
of gravely curtained window sills
laid corms to rest in darkest earth;
until those peaceful words held worth.

As clanking bells tolled hours to stone,
through sleepy Sunday morning stroll;
in golden seasons, all alone,
we saw that crowded family whole.
Ten thousand margins danced their way,
all heads spent to a brighter day.

When standing by that cottaged lake,
or in a pensive mood, at rest,
still golden daffs cannot mistake
that dreadful early treasured chest.
Tossing our heads, no clouding care,
for blissful solitude was there.

STEPPING STONES

I wandered through the park; the church
all clanging clank from Ambleside,
intoning Sunday. Past Stock Ghyll,
I crossed the River Rothay's flow
and bent uphill with shallow breaths.
Each scene? All perfect little deaths.

And though I've crossed those stepping stones
before, to route to Rydal Mount,
then watched those leaping sheep descend
beneath impressive Heron Pike.
This time, my pounding heart: a drain,
to meadow graze that sweeping plain.

Such imprecision – balance warped –
as every step I wavered, strained
to tread on leering teeth of stone.
Pinched, I crossed slowly, muscles weak,
as waters rushed me far downstream
and left me walking in a dream.

GRASMERE

I wandered chilly as a crowd
of thundering traffic, rumbling slow,
when all at once I heard quite loud,
wild Herdwicks bleat near water flow.
Shivering, trembling roofless breeze,
this cameo had power to please.

I tremored, lurched and ogled sights,
to freeze-frame every scene that passed.
Though it was Wordsworth's own, by rights,
and his the view that would outlast
my coach past Rydal Water's chill,
then breaking sunshine: Grasmere's thrill.

I took the daffodil path beneath
a huddling grave, like tomes that lay
beyond all sunshine words to wreath
the river rushing time away.
Cruising home, for home I must,
I left that dovecote, held in trust.

BETJEMAN IN GRASMERE

Oh, my darling, kiss and cuddly,
you're so muddly and so huddly,
not like a sweet Lake Poet in the spring.
Watch that ribbing tennis elbow,
where you lie so calm and noble.
Take up croquet; or join the choir and sing.

Oh, my lovey-dovey, lazy,
here your silence drives me crazy.
Those pilgrims crave the audience of a saint.
Could you boom-boom just a little,
with a haunting laugh – quite fickle.
You're lying in the silence, musing quaint.

Though in Advent I love church bells,
poets should be busy. Hell's bells.
I fancy fish 'n' chips and well-chilled beer.
All that foreign tourist aura,
I'm for pulling pints and Laura.
You're stiff from tennis. Well, I'm outta here.

LOUGHRIGG TERRACE

I wandered only bent and cowed
through woodland, skidding rocks and bog.
My heart was thumping very loud,
all apprehensive fell-hard slog.
Descending like a river bed,
my bones all rattling in my head.

We sat on Baneriggs, by the lake,
cascading waters cheered its show
in storm and sunshine, mallard wake
to River Rothay's overflow.
In solitude we sat and chewed,
as seagulls danced and dived for food.

Much later, pensively, at rest,
I'll wake those Loughrigg Terrace heights
with aching limbs, slow heaving chest
and dreams of Grasmere's songbird flights.
That vast expanse will soon reflect
in flesh-abandoned sweet neglect.

I SHOULD HAVE LOOKED AFTER ME FEET

I should ‘ave looked after me feet.
They were rested and warmed a treat.
Now blistered and sore and in pain,
oi don’t think oi’ll come ‘ere again.
Me female assets, headed south,
meet swollen feet up to me mouth.

I should ‘ave looked after me feet,
with views everywhere – here’s a seat.
But men like to walk in the rain,
see lakes and black sheep all again.
Me best view’s well-hidden, sat down,
not trailing each walker through town.

I should ‘ave looked after me feet.
They like to spa shingle and peat
from bottles; not splashing to stain.
Me outfit is ruined again.
So next time he sez, ‘Are you done?’
I’ll snore. Then abashed, he will run.

CONISTON

The Old Man's Beard was spreading, white
and sun shone brightly into spring.
Brash daffodils, some spent, packed tight
in verges where pied wagtails sing.
Meandering past shops, we stopped
and shopped and shopped until we dropped.

We wandered lonely, for the bard
of Edinburgh had gone back home.
But tomes of Ruskin shades all sparred
with walkers' guides for all who roam.
Dark Herdwicks grazed in fields like clouds
away from tourist tracks and crowds.

The winding route to Ambleside,
past dancing hosts of daffodils,
left my bumped stomach churned inside
like flowers on high windowsills.
At Lakehead, water skirred around,
my stomach contents hit the ground.

STOCK GHYLL

Don’t wander up Stock Ghyll’s sheer deep,
with tripping roots and mossy rocks.
Nor Wansfell Pike, that rises steep,
without thick shoes and woolly socks.
Don’t look at daffodils, nor stop
to watch that rushing, gushing drop.

Don’t pause and stare, or hope sun-dance
will freeze-frame perfect motion still,
as sparkling waterfalls shall prance
beyond each stepping daffodil
that gathers force in airy cloud
of nothings, to your stumbling crowd.

Descend quite slowly, saplings strive
to bump your brow; uprooted trees
ensure, in time, you will arrive
in gully… any way you please.
Just take my word that daffs don’t dance,
they simply twitch at fickle chance.

SOPHIE AT RYDAL WATER
[iso Sophie Hannah]

If you don't care about the way
you look a sight, when out to play;
then I don't either. Nor the sound
when you stride out and boom around.
It really doesn't matter if
life gets no better off than this.

I know you think your verse is best:
all fulsome, womanly, undressed.
But that was before Women's Rights.
We've viewed – like – men; we've seen some sights.
So if we choose to write like Will,
those blooming daffodils are still

outside Hotels Like Houses, bright
in garish yellows of the night.
But I would sooner herald spring,
by woolly jumpers, socks that sing;
fit hikers' trousers, legs and bums,
brash daisy darlings with their mums.

FELIXSTOWE BARD AT GRASMERE

I'm blowing bubbles, swimming hard
beneath this beautiful big lake.
I know that, up above, this bard
is making shadows in my wake.
I only want to swim in peace,
not thrash and splash to my decease.

My family has lived here since
our grandsire was a slippy fry.
Wordsworth, booming in the distance,
scared the natives. Their hooks twitched by.
I ripple, supple as a cloud,
but up above: a thunder crowd…

I thrash and gasp, no booming bard
still dares to hike, nor ode and shout.
The fisherman is reeling hard…
I'm quite unsafe, until a lout
peddles past: he's booming, grooving.
I now find booming music soothing.

TYNESIDE BARD UP KIRKSTONE PASS

Though spring shall bring the blackbird's song,
a foodleflap is much more fun
round lurching bends, it was quite long
to view through Kirkstone Pass and stun
past streaming clouds' eternity,
descending to the lake, to see,

a flash of graveyard, dancing past
and, there, a field of yellow – vast
as finest daffodils of spring
spread widely over everything.
If I could pause, switch off the car,
there birdsong would have thrilled me far.

When snaking round Ullswater's steam,
past fields of sheep and fickle clouds
of daffodils and bracken; dream
those pensive pigeons: bobbing proud,
will gleam my inward eyes like seas
that gravely dance and, golden, please.

AIRA BECK

We left the lake, archiloquent
with rising steam and breaking clouds.
The early downpour quivered, spent,
as sunshine spread to absent crowds.
Ullswater sailings cancelled, how
to spend those fitful hours now?

Though daffodils were trying, could
be seen in patches, golden, spread.
Only in sunshine, understood.
Or climbing Aira Beck, ahead:
there gushing gullies gleamed and shone
in solitude, when words, long-gone,

could paint my inward eyes with bliss
of steam and spray in Eden's light
of greater gold, when we might miss
those daffodils in summer's night.
Glenridding drenched us, but we danced
past waterfalls that leapt and pranced.

BOWDERSTONE BEYOND DERWENTWATER

It rained in Keswick, to the brow
of Ruskin's earliest memory:
as wind gushed, swept around and how,
a Friar's Crag and inland sea.
Sweet Derwentwater's storm-clad child,
embrangled daffs, that danced and smiled.

The Jaws of Borrowdale rose steep,
in flood below sweet bridges, framed
by slate and pastures, grazing sheep,
to glacial Bowderstone: inflamed
by ladder, climbing to fresh air,
where there's just room to stand and stare.

But do not think to wander round,
nor visit – lonely – in despair,
or you will rock that bolder ground
to blooming poppies everywhere.
Lean on that boulder; it won't shift,
and from beneath see sweet gold drift.

AMBLESIDE

I love sweet Ambleside in rain,
damp running slate drips like a drain.
A never-ending stream flows through:
of Lakeland traffic with a view.
The mountains like to fall down here,
where clouds don't reach to mist or clear.

There hikers trek about to buy,
preambling parents pause and try
to wind round treats of every shade
of taste and price and real home-made.
A surfeit / plethora of cooks
and all the obvious poetry books.

When resting back at home, the tug
of Jacob's pensive sheepskin rug
will fill my eyes with Lakeside rain,
until I feel such bliss again:
a dwarf shop straddled on a bridge;
a Wordsworth, signed and unabridged.

JOHN CLARE AT WATERHEAD

It poured with rain at Waterhead
and not a crow nor wren I saw.
Though, I declare that, there instead
were boatswains, skippers, gulls and more:
local daffodils on the green;
gossiping, clearly to be seen.

Then I walked into Borran's Park
too early for a nightingale.
No meadowsweet nor pleasing lark.
Dilapidated farmstead, stale.
Just banks of drifting daffs, thin air
and brooding lake to stand and stare.

Dark Wansfell Pike lay in thick cloud,
as I walked, dripping, into town.
The Fairfield Horseshoe, standing proud;
when looking up as it looked down
-though sadly it was not a crow –
the robin gave a perfect show.

KEATS IN THE PARK

I gazed upon the midnight air
as silence, like consumption, grew.
I wept the moon, which could outstare
the sweetest sigh that, so brand new,
could flaccid, raise my shading dark
(though it was daytime in a park).

Sweet Ruth, stark hopes raised Boaz' seed,
of naked drunkenness to corn.
He startled, wakeful, heard you plead.
In nine short months, his son was born.
Such stars shine for my nightingale,
as I grow weak and deathly pale.

Will no-one hear my sweetest sound
-this waterfall of ecstasy -
when I lie deep beneath the ground?
Such drifting silver, dancing free
as moon-walks, giggling to Adieu!
Such late liaisons are too few…

HIGH SWEDEN BRIDGE

I wandered lonely as a cloud,
when all at once, from far behind,
a massive walking party crowd.
So we walked slow, each twist and wind,
until a panting, muddy hound
dropped his prize stick upon the ground.

I slithered over the long ridge,
a host of strident shades all sat,
to frame the view: High Sweden Bridge.
Then they all turned and looked round at
my bump and tumbling, thudding skud
on my posterior in the mud.

When on my chaise longue, for a rest
in blissful solitude, to pen
posterity at its lean best,
I will not mention that slip, when
I framed tight breeches, to appear
immortalised in mud – my rear.

THE STRUGGLE

We cruised to Townend, where the gloom
of dark oppressed us in each room.
Though Beatrix Potter stayed here, we
could not think of her writing, see
how she could sketch or paint a scene,
of clouding rain, all fresh spring-clean.

We drove to Troutbeck's clouding gold,
all verging drystone walls. Though cold,
with crowding mists on all those hills,
yet packed with dancing daffodils.
All Human Nature is built where
it's natural to stand and stare.

A host of sheep in meadow, fell,
delightful rushing stream as well.
Our spirits rose to Kirkstone Pass,
where all around us was a mass
of great distractions from the route;
with steaming clouds and falls, to suit.

When I think of that pensive drive,
down The Struggle to stay alive,
my inward eyes will fill with rain
and sunbeams when I reach the plain.
There, Ambleside, (with brakes) is blessed,
but now the driver needs a rest.

LOW SWEDEN BRIDGE

I ambled amiably, uncowed,
my flouting thoughts in valleys, hills.
I did not want to meet a crowd,
all hosting shades of daffodils.
Belabouring up through the trees,
my heart a-flutter in the breeze.

Contiguous rocks, with water-shine,
all twinkled, dripping, far away.
An ever-stretching, reeling line
beyond where fishers tempt or prey.
Ten thousand steps could not enhance
our heads, tossed back to gaze or glance:

High Sweden Bridge in flood, at play,
a sparkling, rushing symphony.
Though poets could have stayed all day,
my jostling youth bored fast, to see
panoramas that could be bought.
So I tripped on each stumbling thought,

slipped vacant in my notepad. I,
stock still in blissful solitude
beneath a tree, (I could not fly).
No pen recorded, then, my mood:
though my heart now with pleasure fills
and dances where the warbler thrills.

AIRA FORCE

Struggle and pant up Aira Beck,
there is no finer bedrock course.
In steam and spray and heaving wreck,
the sweeping fall of Aira Force:
enchanting in simplicity,
revealing true dexterity

of angel-dance before The Fall,
when they crawled up a fern or reed
to dry moist wings, to spread them all
where thrashing silver leaps to feed.
Just so, first angels raised blue sky
of Paradise above first fry.

The Crystal Sea, the Throne of Grace,
in clockwork motion's night and day.
There is no other, better place,
where Eden hangs – if it could stay –
on golden chains before The Fall:
where it could force and still enthral.

When back at home, Ullswater's dress
will gush and flood in rising steam:
each dragon, damsel, angel tress
will feed my solitude, to dream
enraptured water-folding light
in Aira Force of fly's first sight.

LA MÉRIDIENNE OU LA SIESTE

I wandered only as a cloud
past endless blooming fields of rape.
I did not boom (it's not allowed),
in that half-holy dream landscape.
I could not sleep in fields of corn.
So was my tired sprite reborn?

The Roslyn Poet barely left,
when I trod to Elysian streams.
The Grasmere Bard stilled love to theft,
beyond dull stone, where ending seems
a dancing host of daffodils
in fields and verges, window sills.

Where, on a green hill far away,
beyond Kinneret's diamond spark,
a lamb-crossed skyline will convey
another mirrored lake, a lark:
rising and falling winds to wing
all that the angels mean to sing.

I slept on in my lover's arms,
in nubivagant golden drift.
There, mountain water, flowing, calms
mansuetude of bird alarms.
Ruth bends the midnight air to grief
of golden harping spring's relief.

FAST FOOD

He lay on the window ledge
and such a splendid fellow.
I don't know how William Wordsworth died,
as he lay leaving there.
No-one cried to see him gone,
nor buried him inside the fast food outlet.
He strayed inside and swept his sweeping breath,
or, maybe swotted, died of too much sugar.
I hate him, William Wordsworth,
and yet, when dead,
he breathing breathed no more.
That was a shame:
lying on the window still
and I don't know who shushed his perfect form:
all waistcoat, breeches, hairy legs
and vibrant yellow stripes.

CHICKEN

There, in the field, a little Beatrix Potter
clucking away among the Queen of Sheba.
No sign of pastry cottages,
nor kittens with milk,
yet she was in her element with Mr Raven:
in the library with a flock of starlings.
And how John Keats shone like a field of clouds.
No leaps nor leapings in their rise and fall,
for spring was springing berries of drystone walls.

ROAD KILL

I left the leavings of Robert Southey
beside the road.
He wasn't going anywhere,
his breathings had gone
and never could he leap his leapings more,
to dance with twigs and shake his trunk.
Poor Mr Southey saw with no more seeing
and that is sad for scribbled scribbling; more
leaves that left their leavings on the ground.
I think he could not bury any nuts
and someone might dig diggings for Mr Southey.

HIGHWAY

Round about Bolsover Castle,
the Queen of Sheba spread across the hillside.
All Friesian dress, she turned her hide behind
and faced away to lean into each camber
of fields ploughed into stubble stubbling chins,
that cruised along the Motorway far away.
And everywhere the Queen of Sheba went,
she spread posterior presence full of pats,
to cumbersome uphill in contoured fields.
And only one, a Queen of Sheba, sat
to ruminate her wisdom to the sod.
All the rest, each Queen of Sheba hide,
stood grazing on dull clods, tails tailing back
and all the harvest fields were gathered in.

THE LAKES

The first sign of The Lakes
saw a depression of Emily Dickinsons
huddled under a tree,
bewildering clouds glowering
to simply stunning rain and raining
with a sceptre in the sky.
The orb of all England, beyond Wakefield.
While, spread across the sheeting grooves
of mud and blood and cloven hooves,
there Thomas Hardy planed the landscape broadly:
as Tess laid on an altar stone.

And everywhere I saw with seeing, there
were Thomas Hardies all around,
each spread in pretty clouds;
symmetrical as prayer.
I hope that Emily will soon rein in
those fiercesome hermits scurrying in their shine.

IN FLIGHT

Then Charles Dickens delightfully
danced around a telegraph pole,
dressed like a magpie, penguin,
or the Queen of Sheba.
It sickens in sickliness
around the roundy roads
and up and over the breast of the Iceni gorgon
(that raged and raged against the dying
of woad in Londinium).

THE BRIGHTEST STARS

And then I saw John Keats, he bleated loudly
as moonlight/stars, all pastured in their heavens.
As far as looks could looking
see – like hills – and John was everywhere,
as scribbled surf,
for surely it said ‘John’
all inked in water.
So splidge splodge all the way,
for signs to Kendal
with mountains spread and spreading
all-glistering bright.
Like a Kay; with a pair of blue eyes.
Except, Thomas wasn’t sad anymore,
all oceans above the railway track,
with John Keats bleating loudly
across the sky.
And one soliloquy for Thomas
gliding above the tide.

RISING HILLS

And so I read readings every mile,
as Mr Raven's three hags flew across the road.
Yet was this birds or desk?
I had no idea.
For a hard time we had of it – not!
With flow and fall of John Keats
and the Queen of Sheba.
Then we came to a pleasant land,
without dancing girls or midwives,
and no trees on the skyline of so many hills.
Phoebus burned us as we hit the rough;
then stomachs lurched with looks that looking rise
to beautiful springing leaps
all across the blue.
There John Keats looked and leaping leapt
like the brightest star.

IAMBIC FEET

So morning rose to Robert Browning and Mrs Titmouse
and, while The Ode Less Travelled could have stayed at home,
a rousing chorus of Iambic pentameters followed:
as Trochaic feet raised ceilingwards,
performing a Hymn and Hera of Lakeland morning.
And though Robert had no poetic soul,
Mrs Titmouse giggled at Spondee formation.
For Hymn and Hera, together, provide equal stress.
And, while the rest is French (all accent and all poetry),
Robert reached Pyrrhic feet and then rolled over
as Mrs Titmouse giggled and considered Wordsworth.
Thus, in the former printing works of Ecclerigg Place,
one Hera contemplated a future Pyrrhic Ode.

VIEWS INTO WINDERMERE

There, a pair of Darcies, in a nice warm coat,
unsaddled in a field of green
and a dripping of clouds.
A Hymn and Hera were walking their walks
to a sea.
And oh, what a see and a sail,
there at Windermere.
On the third hour, we sealed our tombstone hope;
(though we were not at sea, nor on a pier)
and yet, a little tombstoning is a dangerous thing,
so we passed Low Wood and our first Jane Eyre.
She panted up the hillside with her owner,
for she was – plainly – leashed
and without a basket.
(I mean, no Baskerville was so far north,
though his shades of Dylan Thomas raged
in storm clouds every day and without a Herdwick).
So we arrived,
to a glistering of Amblesides
and highs and lows and rounds.

TUCKED IN

When we first came here to Cringol
Cottage, beside the Printer's Cottage,
Rocky was cosseted in a car seat
and Beautiful was, well, as
beautiful as he could possibly be.
So, crooning into a grey down slumber,
Elizabeth Barrett Browning roosted night
and Robert Browning sat beside his Peter Rabbit,
on the double bed for our arrival.
A simple refurb, tastefully redesigned,
to simply allow Elizabeth a cosy nest
beside the RC Church in Ambleside.
Our long-haired Byron glowered
into strength, to try the simple
pleasures of a cottage lie-in
and there, beside the road,
a Hymn and Hera,
deep in conversation beneath Barrett Browning.
I hope she croons and fluffs her feathered breast,
so Robert sleeps his sleepings and chills to love,
at dawn, beside the church; with Peter Rabbit.

EYEBALL TO EYEBALL

I do declare, a Baudelaire, or perhaps it is John Clare?
There – sweeping across the road,
there – beside the cottage gate,
there – with his chestnut prey:
carrying its carrion
eyeball to eyeball,
beak to meat,
no time to speak nor zoom.
Poor Mrs Titmouse humped away for lunch.
John Clare is, oh, so cool;
his fiercesome load
weighted across our looks of lookings
and never have I seen such beak and claw.
So wild, John Clare.

And then, trembling on stepping stones,
no coward spirit there!
We walked the short way round,
beside River Rothay,
past endless Jane Eyres
all leashed for an early stroll
and one, so fiercesome, panting,
one White Shuck,
and how we trembled beyond John Clare
until, crossing the Bridge over Troubled Waters,
Sir Isaac Newton was bobbing along;
his bottom in the stars,
furiously bubbling against the current.
Holding his breath and pecking under boulders;
ploughing a furrow of planets beneath the bridge.

LOUGHRIGG TERRACE

And so we came to a pleasant country,
where lingering is compulsory
along Loughrigg Terrace and beside Grasmere.
But, set down
this, set down
this was bitter agony for us – not!
The Grot of Rydal Hall was...
extraordinary.
Daffodils bloomed within my inner eye
which is the bliss of solitude –
in sight of Dora's Field.
Where blackberries ripened, hydrangeas bloomed
and sunshines slept their sleepings beneath the sod.
So, when we stopped beyond many John Keats's,
glowering pewter and gleaming white;
one knelt in prayer, considering Dora
and so chewed the cud, contemplating
intricate patterns upon the grass.
Later, when we took mermaids with us,
the glowering of Low Wood puced to pewter.
His life was writ in water,
spreading Windermere to storm a storming.
And though John Clare was full, his cousin,
William Blake, darted, dancing, diving,
flitting across his storm.
With such experience, time mattered nothing;
so the experience of little Blakes
beamed like a supermoon of Nureyev/Fontaine.
These ugly uglings glowed like quivering ghosts,
beside a flotilla of bobbing Sir Isaac Newtons.
And then – my soul – the lake break; break/s; and breaks.

CANVAS

Such expanse of sky and light and hills,
a focused panoramic lens of heaven.
Bird of prey, your carrion life enthrals!
Silence; death; an absence of confession.
Here, eyes dart into a vast horizon,
uncluttered by each detail that is bringing
beauty, moments, sights for contemplation.
Glass or glister? Sunshine? Storm clouds winging

Wordsworth? What is there that's left to write?
From Loughrigg Terrace, crystal bleeds its goblet.
Seagulls, ducks or dogs? Each canvas bright.
Bliss: see, store the shoreline drawn in bracelets.
Light on light rethreaded into cloudburst.
To drink, to dream, where solitude drank first.

MOODS AT RYDAL MOUNT

Red is the sky and so blue is the season,
green is the lake and its depths for a reason.
Overflowing over the waterfall –
and down crash the rocks into fall falling fall,
pooling and fooling the dark/shine/light, spoiling
Paradise everywhere. Paradise gleaming
denseness and sparsity, birds on the wing.
Singing and winging my heart to the skyline,
bringing me silence and peace and a pause;
pregnant and beautiful sun in a womb.
Birth in my death; and twilight taken home.
Rhythm. Abruption. Blood in my waters,
William Blake follows me, yet into dreaming
of glorious nature, heartbreakingly gone.
And in a little while –the hourglass empty –
a cuckoo calls at Rydal Mount. He's gone.

JENKYN'S CRAG

Nothing in the staggered steep to Jenkyn's Crag
except, the view to die for
and a few Jane Eyres.
Eyrie is the view of Windermere,
magniloquent its spread
of edge and drop and stop, stop, stopping into sky.
Then we passed through Skelghyll Woods,
without a Peter Rabbit nor Robert Browning,
until the pause to sigh for, beside a path,
where snow-bells, blue as bluebells, gleamed
and in the grass, all Fibonacci forms of buttercups.
Except, eyes saw no seeing for these were dandelions.
And so we passed a farm, a tractor, and Emily Dickinson,
grazing along, her udders full,
that paused, then pensively leaned in
to the fence, for a lasting scratch.
Then all of heaven filled with hallelujahs.
Dickens danced and dived and, darting, flew
both in and out and all around,
with William Blake's broad innocence in his flow.
So the walking passed in a pleasant country,
until Troutbeck and gardens of glowering Heathcliff.
No coward soul, to sit beside a farm
with chuckling water underneath our seat,
with cheap and twitters from the telephone wires,
where Blake made such a Dickens of the view:
all flit and flutter, pause to peck and pair
(though there were many hydrangeas into autumn).
What's left to say, except all fields were full
with all the brightest stars (and these were writ in water).
And, overhead, John Keats spread across the sun
into a brooding hermit, wearing a kagoul.

TROUTBECK

Bravely stepping over the Iceni gorgon,
William Wordsworth dallied with Robert Browning;
idle curiosity buzzed and flamed,
with never any sighting of Peter Rabbit.
Beyond a Keatsian sky, a hermit scudded
across the ocean of my seeing sea.
There, trampled and trashed by a raging Londinium,
Percy Bysshe Shelley lay his nuzzle to the ground.
His Fibonacci form, although intact,
held no breaths of breathings,
nor wriggles nor snufflings nor runs.
With scenery to die for, there he lay
and I hope someone buried him until he grew,
beyond Troutbeck, at Jenkyn's Crag –
his soul an eyrie
of Frankenstein in flight over Windermere.

DERWENTWATER

At Keswick, an incarnation of William Blakes,
a cackle of Goosey Ganders, all bottoms-up,
and Thomas Hardy flapping on a solitary rock.
There, every flotilla captured a photograph.
And each human form? A Fibonacci.
Then, beside the park, a bite of Dante's
Inferno, clouding to a Lakeland storm.
Airs breathed their breezing into song,
as buskers sold their art so cheap
and crazy golf collaborated with perfect sunshine.
Rest here awhile; inside a Royal Bengal,
then dream of 1,001 Arabian Nights.

HOT TUB

Descending into the mermaid's kingdom
at Windermere,
we floated, soaked and splash and tickled steam.
Pastures spread and dropped from such great height,
that we were dizzy in our dizzying drop
and, in a hot tub, there we saw John Keats
grazing along and trimming the hotel lawn,
so green and seasoned that we all looked up:
and there we saw the seeing of the vast and deep.
Yet this was too much experience for William Blake
and all we saw, between the sheep/blue eyes
was dipping, darting, diving with Dickensian speed.
Charles was so at home beside the lake
and how we hubble bubbled like
Mr Raven's three hags.
Delicious susurrations of our skin,
we left with aching limbs, walked round the lake
to Waterhead, as a hermit began to pinch
and spit and frolic – so Keatsian – beyond the blue.
Sheepish, we were born, to dream of stars
and so, again, his life was writ in water.

ON THE DOORSTEP

There is a naked man and he's standing in the doorway,
he has a naked torso and he's worth a second look.
The sky is not as naked as this man stood in his doorway,
the hidden bits are misty and they're worth another look.

There are a pair of fearsome hounds all bounding round the courtyard,
they're blackly in their nakedness, I cannot bear to look.
They snuffle, pant and dribble, soon they'll leap out of the courtyard
and pamper my seat on the bench; I cannot bear to look.

The naked man is smiling and he's standing in his doorway,
if they make friends I'll have to speak and take another look
at his naked torso, or the sky; there's a god and he's in his doorway.
I howl and howl, he calls them back without a second look.

COUPLE AT WATERHEAD

She's short and grey and confident. She stands
beside the lake. She looks towards its gleam;
while he is taller, stouter, arms hang; hands
appear stuffed in his pockets. It would seem
he knows the lea and lie of boats afloat.
She mirrors his perspective. She looks too,
and he could walk on water for a boat.
She would be happy with his every view
and, there in silhouette, a stick leans by,
in case she cannot manage his weight. Now
he hesitates beneath a harboured sky
of greyly glistering, as hours allow.
They are a diptych centrefold, they bend
together, anchored, ready to defend...

A LUCKY HORSESHOE

In the long-ago when I was dead,
the Coffin Route was more than I could fly.
So, seated here, the stone is growing colder,
for tucked inside, at bedtime, is William Wordsworth.
I seemed alive this morning, at Ambleside,
yet, seeing Jemima Puddleduck (with her eager splash)
was nothing; beneath the horseshoe
with its gentle mount.
Deceptively, Mr Darcy beckoned on
and so we climbed each staggered steep,
until I saw Ode to a Nightingale
spread storming across the pastures.
(Since Ode to a Nightingale may grace the day,
there were many Odes in various shades;
for young Odes, born of night, wear a dark coat
that fades into a supermoon at the last.)
And there, an Ageling, he was called a Wightingale.
These are the brightest stars, each Ode so true
as Lakeland everywhere, in staggered steeps.
So, when the clouds did their clouding
at the top and down and up again,
nothing else was there, except Mr Raven.
We entered the clouding clouds,
all nacred with joy and glister at the top
and when there was no more seeing,
but only damp and cold,
we shivered at the cairns and drystone shelters.
There, on the floor of heaven,
a little William Blake danced alive in light.
Before the Fairfield Horseshoe vanished into unknowing,
there were such sights as Xanadu all around.
The full spread of Windermere
and Coniston Water, Ullswater,
Grasmere, Rydal and, there on the horizon,
a ship on the Irish Sea.

Such glister, glowering clouds,
a snaking Rothay.
Everything to die for, hour on hour.
And oh, and oh, how I tried to die.
Then, as the steep descent began to toll,
frostbitten fingers; walking poles effeminate.
There, Mr Raven raged to call for dinner,
as staggered steeps of prey descended
slowly.
To Rydal Mount, beside the Coffin Route,
and there my legs sat down and refused to walk.
Beside the gentle breath of Wordsworth, sleeping,
I scribbled as the sun set chilled to dusk.
And, all this time, where was Robert Browning?
Taking the Iceni gorgon, to provide a chariot.
Food, wine, hot bath, a trip to the Old Smithy
(for fish and chips);
all Paradise beneath Elizabeth Barrett Browning.

GRASMERE

I found William Wordsworth sleeping in his sleeples,
on the staircase before breakfast.
He was drystone, with no breathings,
and so was binned.
There my aching of the night before returned,
as every muscle sang a serenade.
So there was nothing else to do,
but mount with Mr Darcy's saddled mare,
a wheeling reeling chilling ride to Grasmere,
where dry bones were cast, so gravely still.
Nibbling no gingerbread, we
hobbled over pavements pensively.
In blissful solitude, like on the bus,
where Rydal Water tremoured into stillness.
So picture-perfect, Grasmere's shine reflected
our breathless adoration from Loughrigg Terrace.
To say goodbye to Dora and to John,
consuming ice creams (banana and chocolate flavour),
there Mr Raven's cousin, a Dorian Gray,
contemplated the green with a bob and hop.

LUNCH IN WINDERMERE

Nothing much to do at Windermere,
but see where Willy's has gone before
(and Galactic Empire).
Pause a moment, imagining:
the broad and spread and moorings of Bowness,
then stand and stare; full lunch for just £5,
inside the corner pub that's understated.
Ignore the Heathcliff garden, as barely noticed,
then sit awhile beside a Singer sewing machine
and slowly watch the world go by,
while downing a pint.
Lunch is served when ready
and, when it's ready, there's nothing more to say
except, gladioli delight the window ledge;
logs are stacked to the ceiling
against outrageous fortune of fuel bills.
Then, as contentment settles on the stomach:
there, a William Shakespeare and his lesser cousins:
hovering above geraniums on the window sill.
Rest for awhile, with 70s music pulsing
and then your hearts may turn to thoughts of love.

ROUTE TO CONISTON

Then Gerard Manley Hopkins came inscape
and caused such instress on my inward eye,
though he was merely snuffling in the fields;
to sty a heaven, springing in his trotters.
No matter, John Keats shone in every field,
for Lightingales were everywhere,
all the way to Hawkshead.
And while the Iceni gorgon raged and stormed,
her nerves were ragged, coiling like a snake,
where drivers wriggled/passengers breathed in
and loud Hosannas accompanied every mile.
This route to die for, Rothay from the horseshoe,
such Prelude to a glimpsing, shrinking lake
behind hedgerows, trees and hairpin bends.
Silence for the Old Man, or for Ruskin;
Mr Raven rose and raucously left Coniston.

STORMS AND SUNSHINE

I don't like me sometimes, though I usually do my best.
I don't like you sometimes, though you usually do the rest
I don't like them sometimes, though they may or may not do
the things I think important, in the way I think it too.

I don't need the sunshine, the scenery nor the storm.
You don't need sublimely simple airs to keep you warm.
They don't need what we need and I think that that will do.
Some pleasures mirror Grasmere, narcissistic as the view.

THIRLMERE

It is a place to fleet with the Iceni gorgon,
a carriageway to Keswick with a see
to flight past, planely, tumbling into trees
and sky and sightings scribbled in the fast lane.
Pause there, at Thirlmere,
stand and stare, or tread
beside the shore with fleets of driftwood floating
in a tumble stumble chessboard
of kings and queens.
No view to die for, shivering in the calm,
where tourists fail to pause into perspectives.
Rest for awhile and William Blake will call,
as William Shakespeare bobs and buzzes along
the tips of rosebay willow herb,
with his distant cousins;
and then pause, staring, at the darkest deep:
Mr Samuel Taylor Coleridge squashed along the path;
no sniffles in his snufflings to scratch and dig.
There, quiver in your quivering as you leave
a scene to die for; there to
Break. Break. Break.

ON TOP OF THE FAIRFIELD HORSESHOE

Stand on the steep; start to look around
where heaven happens, here a radiant light:
shapes all startled; stop, for they are ghostly.
The cloud is coddling, coats of greying sheep.
Pause; this pleasure's perfect and so dim.
No scenes for sight, just saturated views.
Chill and charter route-maps, course a path
up and down and under; urgent, find
each stumbling steep of condescending ground.

MORE ABOUT THE HORSESHOE

The climb is simple, with a view to see
and walking poles as easy as holding hands.
If it is hard and ragged, yet, to be
aiming high, like love, that comprehends

the rock face and the plateau; it is free
and every slipping-slide is wide, compounds
the cloud of deep unknowing that is me.
Together with the sheep, our ghosting stands.

Descending painfully and slowly, thread
through breaking points; to brake; to barely breathe,
disjointedly regrouping as we spread
the pain and numbness played in each fresh wheeze.

When feet refuse to walk his lesser far,
he strides alone; returning with the car.

HERDWICKS AND CLOUDS

There's heaven on a mountain through the climb
in tangling-tumbling steps to a great height,
until the view's beyond itself, sublime
as silence in a cloud of glowering light.

There's shades of pewter, ash, each wool-wrapped ghost
transfigures to unknowing with no bleat.
They spread into another world, a host
impressing retinal transfers as you meet.

They are like trees and you're left walking round
the edges of their vision fleshed in bone.
A stumble-tumbling back to lesser ground;
they are at home; you're leaving, all alone.

With hell of muscle-wrenching aches and pains,
Their nacreous shells fleeced open as remains.

SIGHTS OF KESWICK

Scene nowhere in one place, where crowds appear
as simple foregrounds, angling to a shot.
They gauge perspective, rise to any spot,
then, in each photograph they disappear.
The lake is perfect in proportion, framed
by rolling hills, by light, by boats, at will,
as if no need is greater in each still
that captures all its essence, when it's named.

So, Derwentwater me to stand and stare
at cackling geese and dipping seagulls' preen,
for there's a silence bathed in every scene;
Persephones of focus beyond compare.

Mount every anglepoise to capture light
nailed over mantels, daubed with fresh insight.

WINDERMERE IN RAIN

It's raining on the lake like it would break,
a torrid quiver on a harbour's view.
To see it lost in mist, one might mistake
its raining on the lake, like it would break
at parting from its sunshine sheen. Awake,
all seasons will beautify it true.
It's raining on the lake like it would break,
a torrid quiver on a harbour's view.

YOUTH

The computer and the Internet are at home
as hours slow to boredom, speed to fun.
The highest-tech gadget is the simple comb
and a camera for all that nature's spun.

New worlds open through each lens and shot,
no standing stare's too great, no frame too small
to capture art for art's sake. What a lot
of digital masterpieces for the wall.

No electronic sideshow scene's released
from perpetual motions of a holiday.
And yet, what youthful stillness was completed
up, down, around and under every way.

The gaze he gave his staggered-stumbling mum
is incomparable. It left me numb.

STOCK GHYLL

It rained and rained and drenched the skins of trees
in every way, more scenes all-dripping taste.
Climbing ever higher through Stock Ghyll,
a straggle of dour rocks and roots, so full.
A flood of echo-filling flooding flows
down through the chasm formed, to pool below.
Water every which way; pause to breathe
and stagger eyeward canopies of sleeves
that spread umbrellas, dripping into gleam
of luminosities that burst with green.
Then step along a pleasant country lane
and startled eyes freeze as you pause the same.
One moment – there – a vanishing dear view,
a graceful glow of limbs soon gone from show.
And there, the mountains vanish into mist,
transfigured into absence, ghosting most.
Unformed as clouds, where Herdwicks stare and graze
on plateaus of a moonscape's spreading nave.
And altars everywhere a font is found,
or precious paddling pools of Wordsworth's rounds.
Past drystone walls and barn, a derelict folly,
such pleasant landscape spreads across the valley.
Then cattle-grids and waymarks to Wansfell Pike,
a flit and flutter dance of William Blakes.
A hide of striped calves/cows in cream and brown,
like Emily Dickinson's all-sturdy brawn.
Alarms of cockerels at the farmyard gate,
as Jane Eyre barks a plainly fearsome greeting.
There, fields of cackling geese and Mr Raven,
startled from his peck and hopping browsing.

A pair of Geoffrey Chaucers, with a beard
and horns and cloven hooves, soon reappeared.
Siegfried Sassoon alarmed the farm again,
with cock-a-doodle-dallies that inflamed
Jane Eyre to bark and paint the sky with sound.
No Lord Byron, so deer, on farmyards stormed.
And there, a Struggle, tumbling round the fields
as far as Windermere and Ambleside.

AT THE PETROL STATION

At Bradford I saw Robbie Burns.
He looked a long way from home.
On the kerb by the petrol station, he stood his ground,
though few understood his dialect.
He waved at each car that filled up
and shook fists at their emptiness on exit.
Then thumbs-up 4 a car, b4 he sat down;
he balanced trapeze on the kerb.
Few noticed his shaking and twitching,
he blended into the hard shoulder.
And, as a grand finalé, his cusped hands
held eloquence and nothing, nothing else.

LEAVING

It's time to leave. Why do I have to go?
Soon autumn falls into the greatest waste.
Feelings might, in moments, overflow.

Will anything remain for future show,
a slowing down of life's perpetual haste?
It's time to leave. Why do I have to go?

The sun sets in its mood and leaves me low
as memories of moments interlaced.
Feelings might, in moments, overflow.

For mellow fruitful mists: a final bow;
too soon to quicken seasons, now fast-paced.
Its time to leave. Why do I have to go?

The winter beckons, drops its gorgeous gown.
Mists chill to perfect gossamers, embraced.
Feelings might, in moments, overflow.

Germinating silently, outgrown
in shortened days, where fattened bulbs were placed.
It's time to leave, why do I have to go?
Feelings might, in moments, overflow.

THIS AND THAT

I don't think I can be a friend to you.
Why you would want it? Life, as you perceive,
buried on some foreign field from view,
so it is gone, like England; so believe

why you would want its life, as you perceive,
though this mound's you and that one's me. It's true,
so it is gone like England. So believe
we separate each day and night seamed through,

though this mound's you and that one's me. It's true,
blood autumn falls to, earthbound, grieve:
we separate each day and night seamed through
with copper, gold or slate, as we receive.

Blood autumn falls, too earthbound, grieve
that friends, like fickle death, are wintry few.
With copper, gold or slate, as we receive:
forever is too short and mined too soon.

Fast friends like fickle death are wintry, few,
buried on some foreign field from view.
Forever is too short and mind too soon.
I don't think I can be a friend to you.

DISINTEGRATION SONNET

The world is falling falling forced apart
disintegrating, danger and destroyed.
If this is all there is, I have no heart
for every sinew's dishcloth is conjoined.

The country's smashing smashing slashed and fractured.
If this is all there is then I don't mind.
Problems pile up, everything's compounded.
Why can't we drop them, leave them all behind?

The town is fine, it's finely balanced, tilting,
too taut to topple, twist, or upturned, lie
without its soul intact, just parties spouting
Pied Pipers on a foul wind, passing by.

The self is failing falling forced apart
and, for the time's rebuilding, I've no heart.

BEYOND STOCK GHYLL

It seems a year is simply one fine day
to climb up slowly, pausing for the view
and focusing on what you might look through
if years were stolen moments gone astray
beyond the gate, the path, the fell-mist way
to nowhere in the silent hills. It's true,
a lifetime in one breath – and those too few –
if then was now, you/me, then we could stay

with Herdwicks, cows and geese, a fresh-faced bunny
sweet with nibbling grass and no known fear;
and Squirrel Nutkin squirming limbs of trees.
Oh, then the past is nursery-bright and funny,
the peace of moments lives because you're here
when my sigh sobs beyond a quelling breeze.

When my sigh sobs beyond a quelling breeze,
the peace of moments lives because you're here.
Oh then, the past is nursery-bright and funny,
and Squirrel Nutkin squirming limbs of trees.
Sweet with nibbling grass and no known fear
(with Herdwicks, cows and geese), a fresh-faced bunny.

If now was then, me/you, then we could stay
a lifetime in one breath – and those too few –
to nowhere in the silent hills, it's true.
Beyond the gate, the path, the fell-mist way,
if years were stolen moments gone astray...
and focusing on what you might look through
to climb up slowly, pausing for the view.
It seems a year is simply one fine day.

THE ELLERAY, WINDERMERE

I do not think I can thank God for this,
a half of cider with a sumptuous lunch,
recalling this pub and the very seat –
where our shrunken family sat in 2011,
soon after my sister died.
After Paris? Perhaps. An 18th birthday,
all luscious light and play of wind and sun,
calmly letting the season pass
to my birthday month, as autumn gold
reflected my youth/ageing here, in every scene.
It's 2015 now. October falls
with all the beauty of death that's tucking in
the Herdwicks, counting them to trek the miles;
and now, that boy – back then – he is 18;
a Fresher face? There are none; let me drink,
to raise a glass: not to an empty nest,
nor energy to climb, nor aching muscle.
Simply: day and night, or sleep and waking,
return... perhaps. Like paddling in Grasmere's sheen.
Angels sing the moment of two boys, paddling.
What happened to them, Pan, did they grow up?
I long for boring days; for growing old.

WATERHEAD TO WINDERMERE GOODBYE

Windermere, like glass, it lies so still,
vast hush of mountains, autumn trees reflecting
perfection, edged in mist, a peace that will
earth-bond to deep, to sky-thrilled contemplating.

Vast hush of mountains, autumn trees reflecting
worrisome motor boats and steamers' drift,
earthbound too deep too sky; thrilled contemplating
absence of man holds silence to uplift

Worrisome motor boats and steamers, drift
like gnats of family life at the water's edge.
Absence of man holds silence, to uplift
a seagull from a swan on some rocky ledge.

Like gnats of family life at the water's edge,
sun risen craft cruise on in brightest morning.
A seagull from a swan on some rocky ledge
cries raucously till midnight stars, adorning

Sun-risen craft. Cruise on in brightest morning...
perfection edged in mist, a peace that will
cry raucously till midnight. Stars adorning
Windermere: like glass it lies so still.

LAKES BY BUS

I have taken the bus not as far as it will go; my better half captured Wansfell
Pike, High Sweden, Red Scree, Loughrigg tarn, and the Fairfield Horseshoe.
Easily to Rydal, escorted slowly past stepping stones, flooded
to Ambleside. At the Giggling Goose, in pouring rain, refreshing coffee,
hopping aboard for Grasmere and a glorious dove.

Fortified next day, changed at Windermere,
up the staggered steep to Kirkstone Pass.
Swooping to Pooley Bridge, I walked the planks,
steamed the length of Ullswater, as Magner's reached the parts.
Alighting at Glenridding, praising Tourist Info/fast-drained coffee,
summer schedules returned me home.

Next day, priding my timetabling abilities, I reached steaming
Haverthwaite, alighting at Newby Bridge,
as all the world (and his children) descended on Lakeside.
Admiring ford/floodwaters, and traffic-flow
I bussed home from Windermere via Bowness.

Next day I took the 77 from Keswick (found it first),
cruised delightful journey butter-mere (slate/forests/walkers/bikers/
ancient gods descending Mount Olympus).
I made it on the X4(5) to Cockermouth
watched raging torrent of under-sevens (amazed William didn't drown);
took sustenance from Fletcher Christian, post-2009, or 2015.
Returning via Keswick, a busker's haunting melody,
vegetarian dinner (at home); and My Cousin Rachel.

Flagging fast (in coach-travel) Coniston, Hawkshead:
young William went to school and drowned…
HIT DELETE. Watched a drowned man late at night,
before family broke and changed forever.
Exhausted, I undersold the delights of Kendal:
coffee/soldiers/cobblestones survived.
At Grange-Over-Sands, I feasted olive oil, artisan bread,
balsamic vinegar, and cider, congratulating
my self-planned circular tour via Newby Bridge.
No connections failed; at Bowness there were shops,
returning home, yet barely spending a penny.
Next day I failed: Newcastle and Lancaster;
husband drove me to Aira Force by car:
a pint at Kirkstone Pass/heady afternoon tea at Waterhead/
an evening of Jazz at Zeffirelli's.
The bus all-GOLD, exploring Lakes in style;
I hope my back recovers to mountain-climbs.

PARADISE LOST IN DECEMBER
['Twins in substance and reflection.' Malcolm Williams/Landscape' card]

In substance and reflection it is there:
etched permanence of trees and vapoured mist.
Sheer golden glows of morning-rise enlist
nature's poets – so it's seen everywhere.

My inner eyes' perfection: winter's snubbed,
for chaise longue solitude of dancing light
on window-pane – or water – this, my sight
sounds like silence when each moment's dubbed.
Perfection tricks new retinas of heaven,
from Crow Park, over Derwentwater. Peace:
ethereal rolling mist/zoom lens release
Landscape of the Year, taken by Paul Bullen.

Blue sky; gold clouds; dark hills; an eyrie heart:
Milton's transient bliss hung down. Apart.

THE 508

I dwelled upon those hidden things,
from Booths in Windermere and passing Bowness:
like a tourist destination – all that brings
in distancing through Troutbeck, Kirkstone Pass.
The Mortal Man lies sweetly dressed in cider,
contemplating climbs to Wansfell Pike.
Flooded with relief, Glenridding's wider:
sailing to Pooley Bridge without the hike.
Each pausing place – like nursery slopes, El Teide,
a Coffin Route of drystone fells and sheep.
Inebriated clouds leap Herdwick's leader,
none grieves her passing pints where it's so steep.
So many Wordsworths fear the crowding bus:
humming, braking, shaking. All that fuss.

ROOM WITH THIS VIEW

Lake Windermere is troubled, gently so,
with flitting seagulls' darkened wings and paddles,
while, back at Bowness, geese and tourist waddles
like yesterday's screamed laughter, long ago.
Today's deep pain appears unending woe,
new sailing boats, canoes, where steamer straddles
bridge and mountain views; still sheepskin coddles:
mothers of fresh lambs beside Rothay's flow.

Now beauty gifts, heart-breakingly with taste,
of dishes spread delicious, as each piece.
Heaven of sorts: like marriage with the dead,
both parents lost too sudden – hellish waste,
like jigsaw shapes, so family maps peace.
A Wordsworth would weave tapestry-backed thread.

THE 508 RETURNS TO WINDERMERE
[In the style of Dylan Thomas]

Rage, Rage against the sighing and the fright!
Your ashes caused such argument: no spoil,
there is no space for flowers bathed in light.

Our mother left before she'd gone so quiet;
and you, my sister, in that ghost-wrung hall,
rage, rage against the sighing and the fright.

For next year – after you – with blond haired might,
my brightest star razed fleshless into soil.
There is no space for flowers bathed in light.

So many since, in pandemic-less plain sight,
my oceans storm and calm/my mountains fall.
Rage, Rage against the sighing and the fright.

The staggered steep of Kirkstone passes tight,
just room enough for sheep, thin air and foil.
There is no space for flowers bathed in light.

And you, my father, son (or daughter) might
post joy in moments like a songbird's call.
Rage, Rage against the sighing and the fright,
there is no space for flowers bathed in light.

THE 555

I wandered lonely as a mother
by Lakeland bus, past drystone walls.
I could not fault the view; another
(man) climbed higher than waterfalls.

Charity shops of Keswick I left alone,
saw Fitz Park, Thirlmere, Grasmere too.
With dodgy knees/a stick, my throne:
all teashops – pit-stops with a view.

St Oswald's under scaffolding; next:
Dove Cottage/Rydal Mount/the Rothay…
I long for Windermere (or a friendly text),
not dancing on my seat post-coffee.

Fragmenting family issues flow,
like Herdwicks/feasts/wine long ago.

THE BOAT TRIP

A sheep ran ahead of the bus.
I can't say, 'In front', as it leapt
hopefully beside the drystone wall.
Running ahead, panicked, the single-decker
packed with passengers/cameras/walking poles/backpacks.
We braked ahead of the narrow winding route (a bridge),
as that bus swept through, not pausing
to stop and stare at two Herdwicks
ambling along sedately: behind.
Sighing relief at narrow escape:
reminded of sheepskin rug, back home.
Next day we took it slow:
hobbling anciently with support (his, plus 3 legs),
we launched up bow on Derwentwater,
absorbed sun-scorched hills, beatific clouds
and memory shots of Cat Bells
and clambering Skiddaw.
It was a walk in the park
for coffee/cake/yesterday's poem
arriving like the Immaculate Conception.
Scenes to die for – oh no, not yet –
70s music and Old Mout cider (Kiwi and Lime);
memorialising Keswick, journeys and destinations.

I WANDERED BOWDERSTONE TO GRASMERE VIA KENDAL AND WATERHEAD…

The bus to Seatoller disgorges at Bowderstone.
Midges like giants infest ripe air of meat and sweat
and raw sunshine-blue skies.
Dodge-swipe and dance to Keswick,
where Derwentwater aches its easy perfection
of rowing boats/canoes/sailors: like wasps.
From Mother's Day to Easter in and out of hospital
dodging fate. Grandma.
Holiday curtailed.
Like farmyard-vicious flies on the sileage heap, grown
children perform the necessary: breath relieved sighs.
Barely expressing grateful thanks to professionals;
no hospital, no answer to the phone. Ringing.
Neighbourly goodness finds – too much, too little:
Grandad,
at home; one last day.
Numb shock takes a man up Skiddaw,
cooling the heat of early morning phone calls.
Tremoring anxiety takes a woman by bus, to the farthest
reaches of iconic perfection.
Holiday – soon to be curtailed.
Can relatives/friends regroup?
Shall we tell the lie to non-religious?
67 years of married bliss. Together again.
The hills are framed: a perfect sunshine day.
Such effort; such waste. I could wander beside:
a dove/a cuckoo clock… gravely,
today.

I WANDERED ABLE-BODIED BY BUS

Great place to meet
hope your journey was smooth.
Bus from the station, yes,
it's the best way to travel here.
See more, relax. Coffee?
Oh, yes, couldn't miss it,
the old apple store…
it's iconic, dinky, photo opportunity.
Where did you book to stay?
Well, so much choice,
but not for car drivers.
Definitely not for wheelchair users.
You do? Well, there are ways,
something for everyone.

It's after 12, so how about
the staggered steep (2 mins, guaranteed),
best place for Old Rosie at the Golden Rule.
No food though. Pork pie?
The Butcher's almost next door – the best.
We can take things slowly. Yes. I'm sure.
If you're bringing the family later
let me show you the Rock Shop.
Eyeball minerals and semi-precious,
oh, yes, lapis lazuli… and a rock pool.

There's a New Age place next door,
I'm sure your in-law will enjoy.
We could pub crawl, food crawl,
do you need a pair of boots?
There's a park, yes, ice creams,
but they're refurbing the tennis courts,
try the park by the river, children's playground,
a short circular, bit steep, great views,
shame the stepping stones are underwater.

Live Music Thursdays and all weekend,
Zeffirelli's, oh, Fenelli's has disabled access.
Excellent bus service, both ways,
no, that's bit of a trek.
Closed for refurb, at the Pass,
you could try The Mortal Man,
no, steep hill from the main road.

Yes, there's a garden centre, massive,
all the Christmas knick-knacks,
of course, family take the boat.
Round trip, or bus back, Open Top.

I recommend China Cottage,
best prices cheaper side of town.
Italian, Thai, not found the Curry house.
Library by the bus terminus,
Tourist Info and Post Office
on the corner to those rocks.

Of course, start with the Ghyll,
bit steep but delightful.
No wheelchair access obvs.
There's a new cafe at the top,
park up there, vigorous stroll,
she will barely notice you've gone.

A full day's best, steep circular
with benefits. Wind in your face,
views all round, quote William
to your heart's content…
He scared a few locals rhythm-walking.
Skelghyll Wood, Jenkyn's Crag, Troutbeck,
Wansfell Pike, steep steps down down down
Stock Ghyll, then treats at the Apple Pie.

NOTES

A number of poems have previously appeared in:
Wordsworth's Footsteps/2006/PMP
Countryside Tales/Winter 2005
'It is a Beautiful Evening'/Writing Magazine/2005/Shortlist
Rubies/Summer 2005
I Wandered Only as a Cloud/2009/WWB
Opal's Odes/2011/WWB
2016-09 Metverse Muse
Journey of the Meagre Poet/2016/WWB
Reach (238) 2017-07
Star Tips/128/2018-12
ForTheMany/2022-04/Vol 23
Poetry Place/Radio West Wilts/2022-11/Broadast
Lothlorien/Vol 13/2022, Lothlorien/Vol 27/2023
Poetry Archive/VIDEO2023-06; YouTube
Sarasvati/2023-11, Sarasvati/2022-06/Issue 65
Love's Floreloquence/2023/Inherit the Earth
Littoral/2023-01, Littoral/2024-10
Crystal/2024-07;